

How Citizens are Influenced by Political Party Candidates

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BC has a minority government and leading the 2020 BC Election is the BC NDP who had 47.69% of the 1 883 632 votes with the BC Liberal Party finishing second with 33.77% and the Green party coming third with 15.09% according to Elections BC. These three parties counted for 96.55% of all the votes in British Columbia. Choosing 12 constituencies in BC and comparing them we can see the differences in the numbers, candidates, and which parties are favoured. The majority of voters in British Columbia have shown their support for the NDP party and their commitments toward more affordable childcare, better health care and housing affordability, and more jobs around a clean energy future. Comparing the 12 constituencies, however, shows that depending on the area of the constituency we see a difference in party favourites. An example would be Cowichan Valley. In the Cowichan Valley constituency, we see that the Green party is the favourites, and the bulk of the voters support the Green party's commitments to sustainability, respecting diversity, social justice, and ecological wisdom. Metro Vancouver is the most densely populated area in British Columbia whereas in more northern areas of British Columbia as well as Vancouver Island the population density decreases. Does the geography of each constituency and the people who live there affect political views? Does the politician in any given constituency affect an individual's vote? The NDP party has the biggest share of the votes in the province but in constituencies such as Penticton, Kamloops to North Thompson, and Kelowna to Lake Country the Liberal Party received the most votes. Comparing the candidates from 12 different constituencies, I argue that a citizen's vote is influenced by not only the parties' values and commitments but the candidate themselves. I will show that citizens' votes are influenced by the candidate by research comparing the age, gender, and ethnicity of the candidate.

When voting for political candidates age is a determining factor that has been shown to vary between younger and older people. "Young people are more liberal than older citizens on issues such as same-sex marriage, racial discrimination, and foreign policy." -(Semra, 2021) Sevi Semra argues that depending on the age of a citizen they have different views on problems in society. As awareness for

same-sex marriage, racial discrimination and foreign policy have become more prominent over recent years people are growing up becoming more liberal, but the older citizens who grew up without as much awareness of these social issues have kept their political views. The NDP has the most votes in the 2020 BC Election which is an example of young and middle-aged people beginning to outnumber older people's votes as time goes on because more awareness is being spread each year. Same-sex marriage has increased by 60.7% from 2006 to 2016 in Canada according to Statistics Canada. This example shows how views are changing with the addition of younger people adding their perspectives in society.

“Existing literature on candidates’ age shows that voters prefer to vote for candidates that are close to them in age.” –(Semra, 2021) This quote from Semra can be backed by the 2020 BC Election through candidates such as Mackenzie Kerr and Justin Kulik. Mackenzie Kerr was the candidate for the Green party in the Prince George to Valemount constituency who is 23 years old. Justin Kulik was the candidate for the NDP party in the Kelowna to Lake Country constituency who is 19 years old. Looking at the age of Mackenzie and Justin we see that their range of voters who may be influenced by age is greatly smaller than candidates such as Shirley Bond and Norm Letnick who's range is greatly larger with the middle age and senior population. Shirley Bond is 65 years old and is the candidate for the Liberal party in Mackenzie Kerr's constituency. Norm Letnick is 64 years old and is the candidate for the Liberal party in Justin Kulik's constituency. Comparing these constituencies and their ridings we can see that the younger candidates both lost to the older candidates by more than 6500 votes. The younger voters may see the young candidates as people who will bring a new perspective into politics, people who can relate to themselves, people that the younger generation needs to share their ideas and views. Young people may vote for younger candidates but the range of voters that can support Mackenzie and Justin based on these reasons is much smaller than the older population. Older politicians may be viewed to be more qualified and knowledgeable leading to the middle age population siding with the senior population which creates a significant gap between party votes.

Does gender affect party structures and who runs for office? In the 2020 BC Election, we can see how a citizen's vote can be influenced by the gender of the candidate. In the Kelowna – Lake Country constituency the NDP, The Green Party and The Liberal party were all represented by male candidates. In the Nanaimo constituency the NDP, The Green Party and The Liberal party were all represented by female candidates. We can see from the votes that both of these constituencies have a clear candidate of who won but looking at constituencies such as Parksville to Qualicum and Penticton as soon as there is a mix of both genders the voting gap decreases prominently. Why does this addition of one other gender change the voting gap so dramatically? “Citizens prefer candidates or leaders that share similar characteristics.” – (Semra, 2021) Semra claims that citizens rely on the characteristics of candidates when voting. Depending on the constituency the population may have more male than female voters. With the addition of another gender added to the candidates the voting gap decreases because now there are more options than just the party platforms. Female voters feel more comfortable voting for another female candidate because not only do they represent the views of the party they also represent the views of women themselves. In BC's 2020 Election we had a variety of combinations of genders of candidates for each constituency. Comparing Nanaimo and Cowichan Valley's constituencies we see that the Green party gets more votes when women are the candidates representing them. This may be because “voters who value honesty are more likely to vote for women than for men.” – (qtd. In Dolan et al, 2004). The citizens of Nanaimo and Cowichan Valley value not only the Green Party and honesty but the way they see

candidates as people. How the voters see women and men decide whether to bring women into the political process or exclude them. Stigmas such as “If only women were more educated if only women would step forward” – (Kittilson, 2020) are boundaries that women must go through in order to even consider becoming a politician. Instead of political parties serving as gatekeepers for the kind of people who run for office, it is the voters and how society portrays men and women.

British Columbia is a very diverse province with different ethnicities from all around the world. As we look closer at the constituencies that make up BC we begin to see diversity less in areas such as northern BC compared to the lower mainland. The Richmond South Center constituency for example has a huge Asian population while the Kelowna – Lake Country constituency has a bigger Caucasian population. The number of votes for a constituency is determined by the enthusiasm that citizens have towards voting. More enthusiasm equals a greater voter turnout. “The suspicion of this generational divide in enthusiasm traces to young African Americans being exposed to... black civilians assaulted – even killed – by police officers.” – (Collins et al, 2020) This quote shows how society affects the enthusiasm of the younger generation when it comes to voting in elections. How the ethnicity of a group of people are valued in your community whether equal or not influences who believes in the form of government that they are under in this case Canada’s parliamentary democracy. If ethnicity is not valued in the community, why should this group have the enthusiasm to vote as they are still being discriminated against by the majority of voters whose candidate wins in their constituency? How society views a certain ethnicity such as Asian, African American, and Indigenous people affects which candidates will do well in their constituency. In the Richmond South Center constituency’s the two candidates were both Asian and in Kelowna – Lake Country constituency’s the candidates were all Caucasian. These candidates show a challenge that other candidates must step over to succeed and represent their constituency. Comparing this example to Semra’s research that “the presence of minority candidates finds that members of those communities tend to support and vote for candidates of their own ethnicities.” Semra’s research fits in perfectly with how

citizens of Richmond South Center and Kelowna to Lake Country constituencies value their candidates. Comparing North Vancouver to Lonsdale and Kamloops to North Thompson constituencies we see that North Vancouver to Lonsdale's constituency is more diverse and multicultural and so are their candidates which resulted in a clear winner for which candidate. Whereas Kelowna to North Thompson's constituency had a much closer voting outcome. The difference between the two constituencies and their results is that a more multicultural community with more multicultural candidates results in more options and traits that citizens look for. Citizens can choose who they relate to ethnicity-wise and the values that come with the candidate as well as the party. The constituency without as much diversity leaves the citizens to weigh their options based solely on the party and their platform.

Are voters influenced by the candidate just as much as they are the party? Age has shown to play a role in voting for a candidate as we can see the younger candidates (Mackenzie Kerr and Justin Kulik) lose in their constituencies by more than 6500 votes to older candidates (Shirley Bond and Norm Letnick). Gender was a shown factor in the influence of choosing a candidate in the Kelowna to Lake country constituency who were represented by all males, Nanaimo constituency who were represented by all females, and Parksville to Qualicum who was represented by a mix of female and male candidates. The male and female represented constituencies had very clear winners while the mixed constituency had a decrease in the voting gap making the outcome very close. Ethnicity as an influencing factor affected how which candidate could represent their parties in their constituencies. Richmond South Center being an Asian prominent constituency had only Asian candidates whereas Kelowna to Lake Country being a Caucasian prominent constituency had only Caucasian candidates. To conclude through these examples of age, gender, and ethnicity we see that citizens base their votes off who has similar characteristics to themselves. Citizens base their votes on similar characteristics because it is like a cherry on top of a political party. Citizens see the party's platforms but also a candidate that they can relate to to help citizens decide who to vote for. Females may look for female candidates, younger voters may look for

younger candidates, African American's may look for African American candidates, all because they believe that these politicians will watch out for the party's needs but for the voters as well.

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